# Anjila Budathoki

anzilabudathoki@gmail.com, 404-203-7842
https://anjilab.github.io/ linkedin.com/in/anjilabudathoki/


Interest Area: AI Safety, Jailbreaking, Blindspots in AI safety training, AI in decision-making, HCI, AI in social science, Applied AI systems, Knowledge Distillation

## About

I am a Ph.D. student at University of Tennessee, Knoxville, with primary research interests at the intersection of AI safety and human-centered AI. My work focuses on understanding and enhancing the trustworthiness and safety of AI systems, including the study of adversarial attacks and defenses, as well as how humans perceive, interact with, and are affected by AI systems. I aim to investigate how AI systems, designed by humans and for humans can collaborate with people in safe, reliable, and socially responsible ways. More broadly, I am inclined toward interdisciplinary research that integrates psychology, social science, linguistics, and computer science to create meaningful societal impact.

## Education

**University of Tennessee, Knoxville** August 2026-
PhD in Industrial and Systems Engineering

**Georgia State University** August 2026
Master's in Computer Science
Overall GPA: **3.99**

**Advanced College of Engineering & Management**, Lalitpur, Nepal November 2015- August 2019
Bachelor's Degree in Computer Engineering
Graduation: February 2020
Letter Grading: $A^+$

## Publications

### Peer Reviewed

- **Anjila Budathoki**, Manish Dhakal, Benjamin M. Ampel, and Yi Ding. 2026. Understanding the Role of Prompt Template in Knowledge Distillation for Safety Alignment. In Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2026, pages 29801–29817, Budapest, Hungary. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- Dipesh KC and **Anjila Budathoki**. 2026. Handoff Debt: The Rediscovery Cost When Coding Agents Take Over Interrupted Tasks. In Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing, pages 17110–17126, Budapest, Hungary. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- Uthman Jinadu, Parsa Ghazvinian, **Anjila Budathoki**, Benjamin M. Ampel, Rajshekhar Sunderraman, and Yi Ding. 2026. Authority Bias in Conversational Search Engines for Academic Paper Recommendation. In Proceedings of the 2026 Conference on Empirical Methods in Natural Language Processing, pages 24548–24568, Budapest, Hungary. Association for Computational Linguistics.
- Jayden Fassett, **Anjila Budathoki**, Jack Morris, Qin Hu, and Yi Ding. "Unobtrusive Universal Acoustic Adversarial Attacks on Speech Foundation Models in the Wild." In Proceedings of the 27th International Conference on Multimodal Interaction, pp. 424-433. 2025.
- Deniz Marti, **Anjila Budathoki**, Yi Ding, Gale Lucas, and David Nelson, "How does acknowledging users' preferences impact AI's ability to make conflicting recommendations?" In the International Journal of Human–Computer Interaction, 2024. - *International Journal of Human–Computer Interaction 2024*

### Work in Progress/ Under Review

- **Persuasive behavior of Personality Induced LLM arguments**
  - Investigating how specific personalities (Big Five - OCEAN) in large language models (LLMs) influence argument generation for polarized and non-polarized topics,
  - Impact on participants' opinion change after exposure to personality specific arguments.,

– Analysing perception of influence, persuasiveness, and source of generated arguments.

## Industry Experience

**Summer Intern 2024 at Toyota Infotech Labs**

- Investigation of utilizing personalization in electric vehicles,
- Analysis of speed prediction based on recommendation-based algorithm.

**YoungInnovations Pvt Ltd.** April 2019-July 2023
*Mid Software Engineer*

- Developed and integrated Google Maps JavaScript API (Places Library), with a focus on Autocomplete functionality; redesigned and refactored UI logic for chart and table components using ApexCharts.
- Led database schema design using tools such as dbdiagram.io and conducted code reviews to improve code quality and maintainability.
- Served as team lead for JavaScript projects, managing development workflows, conducting interviews, and mentoring interns.

## Projects

- **Breast Cancer Prediction Using Neural Networks**: Developed and evaluated a convolutional neural network (CNN) using PyTorch for classifying histopathological breast cancer images into benign and malignant categories (Undergraduate project).
- **Nepal Project Bank Management Information System**: Developed an information system for the Government of Nepal using Node.js of backend services, Express for REST API and React for the frontend, enabling digital tracking and management of national project status.
- **Nepal Census Data Analysis System**: Developed a data analysis and visualization system using Node.js, Vue.js, PostgreSQL, and Prisma to process, visualize, and share housing and population data from the Nepal Census for three municipalities.
- **Sombar**: Designed and implemented an employee management information system using Node.js, React, and PostgreSQL, supporting attendance tracking, leave management, and team-level dashboards.
- **Skill Lab – Career Service Center**: Developed a job-matching management platform using Next.js, TypeScript, Laravel, and Tailwind CSS to facilitate connections between skilled students and hiring organizations.
- **Avo Portal**: Implemented a delivery service portal using Nuxt.js with Google Maps integration to support location-based logistics and goods delivery.
- **E-Sifarish**: Built an information system for local government ward offices using Node.js, React, PouchDB, and Knex.js to digitize application workflows.
- **VoiceInn**: Assisted in a web-based service application using Vue, Python, and TypeScript; implemented backend using python, including a Windows Service application, and conducted performance optimization of jQuery widgets.

## Skills

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| Programming Languages: | JavaScript, TypeScript, Python, C++, |
| Frameworks: | PyTorch, Express, Django, Flask, Tailwind CSS |
| Libraries: | Numpy, Pandas, Matplotlib, Seaborn, React, Next.js |
| Platforms: | Linux, Ubuntu, Docker, |

## Course Taken

- CSC 6850: Introduction to machine learning, CSC 6851: Introduction to deep learning
- CSC 8850: Advanced Machine learning, CSC 8851: Deep learning
- CSC 8370: Data security, CSC 8230: Secure and Private AI

- CSC 8980: Natural Language Processing, CSC 8260: Advanced Image Processing

## Community Involvement

- Participated in Project Association for Computer and Electronics (PACE) club of ACEM Hackathon
- Participated in Hack Day 2021 YoungInnovations Pvt. Ltd
- NASCOIT Paper Presentation